



SOCIAL AND PROFESSIONAL ISSUES

Philippine Data Breaches

Final Project

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BREACH NO. 1 — Commission on Elections (COMELEC)

"Comeleak" — 2016

1. What company was breached (provide brief background)?

The Commission on Elections (COMELEC) is the constitutionally independent body responsible for enforcing all election laws in the Philippines and administering elections, plebiscites, initiatives, referenda, and recalls. Established under Article IX-C of the 1987 Philippine Constitution, it maintains the national voter registration database — one of the largest personally identifiable databases in the country — containing records of tens of millions of registered Filipino voters.

2. When the data breach happened?

On March 27, 2016, hackers under the banner of "Anonymous Philippines" hacked into the website of the Philippine Commission on Elections (COMELEC) and defaced it. They left a message calling for tighter security measures on the vote counting machines (VCM) to be used during the 2016 Philippine general election on May 9. Within the same day, a separate group of hackers, LulzSec Pilipinas, posted an online link to what it claimed to be the entire database of COMELEC.

3. How the data breach was done?

The breach unfolded in two phases. First, Anonymous Philippines defaced the COMELEC website on March 27, 2016, replacing the homepage with a hacktivist manifesto. On the same day, LulzSec Pilipinas exploited a critical SQL injection vulnerability in COMELEC's web-based Precinct Finder and Post Finder applications. By injecting malicious database commands through unvalidated user input fields, the attackers extracted the entire 340 GB voter database and posted download links publicly online.

4. Who committed the data breach if identifiable?

Two groups: (1) Anonymous Philippines — responsible for the website defacement; (2) LulzSec Pilipinas — responsible for the SQL injection attack, data exfiltration, and public posting of the database. Suspect Paul Biteng (20, IT graduate student) was arrested on April 20, 2016 for the defacement; Joenel de Asis was arrested for downloading and distributing the database.



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5. When was the data breach reported to the public and to the authorities?

The breach was publicly disclosed on March 27–28, 2016 by the hackers themselves via social media when they posted download links. A formal NPC investigation commenced in April 2016, and the NPC decision was issued on December 28, 2016.

6. What data was stolen?

The breach exposed the personal information of over 55 million registered voters, including names, birthdays, home and e-mail addresses, and parents' full names. Based on Trend Micro's investigation, the data dumps included 1.3 million records of overseas Filipino voters, which included passport numbers and expiry dates — in plain text and accessible to everyone. Additionally, 15.8 million records of fingerprints were found, along with a list of people who had run for office since the 2010 elections.

7. How was the data breached discovered?

The hackers publicly defaced the COMELEC website on March 27, 2016, and LulzSec Pilipinas posted download links to the entire database the same day. Social media posts about the download links brought public attention. Security firm Trend Micro subsequently investigated and confirmed the scope of the breach.

8. What actions were done by the company during and after the breach?

The COMELEC responded to the NPC's request for a report on the incident and transferred the hosting services of its websites to the care of the Department of Science and Technology's Information and Communications Technology Office (DOST-ICTO). Initially, COMELEC officials downplayed the breach, claiming no sensitive information was leaked — an assertion that was later contradicted by Trend Micro's independent investigation.

9. What preventive actions were installed by the company?

- Migrated website infrastructure to DOST-ICTO with enhanced security protocols
- The NPC investigation highlighted the need for encryption of sensitive biometric data
- The Comeleak became a landmark case shaping future data protection policy in the Philippines

10. What actions were done by government authorities?

- The NBI arrested suspect Paul Biteng on April 20, 2016 for the defacement, and Joenel de Asis for distributing the database



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- The NPC launched a formal investigation (NPC Case No. 16-001), finding COMELEC in violation of Sections 11, 20, and 21 of the Data Privacy Act of 2012
- The NPC recommended criminal prosecution of COMELEC Chairman Andres Bautista for negligence
- Banks were warned against identity theft using the leaked data
- House Resolution 1392 was filed calling for a congressional inquiry into government agency cybersecurity

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BREACH NO. 2 — Philippine Health Insurance Corporation (PhilHealth) *Medusa Ransomware Attack — 2023*

1. What company was breached (provide brief background)?

The Philippine Health Insurance Corporation (PhilHealth) is a tax-exempt government corporation attached to the Department of Health and serves as the national health insurance program of the Philippines. As of 2023, PhilHealth administered health insurance coverage for over 114 million Filipinos, maintaining one of the largest government databases of personal health and financial information in the country.

2. When the data breach happened?

On September 22, 2023, the Corporation suffered a cyberattack from the Medusa Ransomware, which compromised the data stored on some of its servers and local workstations. The primary database was intact and not infected.

3. How the data breach was done?

On September 22, 2023, the Medusa ransomware gang (an international cybercriminal organization) encrypted files on PhilHealth's servers and workstations. A critical contributing factor was that PhilHealth's antivirus software had expired between April 15 and May 15, 2023 — approximately five months before the attack — and the procurement for renewal was significantly delayed. This left systems without active malware protection, creating an opening the Medusa group exploited. The attackers demanded \$300,000 (≈₱17 million) in ransom; when the Philippine government refused to pay, Medusa began publishing the stolen data publicly starting October 3, 2023.

4. Who committed the data breach if identifiable?

The Medusa Ransomware Gang — an international cybercriminal organization known for mass ransomware campaigns worldwide. The attack was part of a broader global campaign, not specifically targeted at PhilHealth.

5. When was the data breach reported to the public and to the authorities?

PhilHealth notified the NPC on September 25, 2023. An NPC investigation was formally opened September 26, 2023. PhilHealth issued a public urgent notice on October 2–3, 2023, after the Medusa gang began publishing the stolen data.



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6. What data was stolen?

The NPC confirmed that 42 million individuals were affected. These included patient medical records, billing files with PhilHealth member records, PhilHealth member records of rebel returnees under the Pamana program, indigent billing records, records of those killed in action, and senior citizens. The NPC said the stolen data involved a staggering 730 gigabytes of information, roughly equivalent to over one million PhilHealth membership registration forms.

7. How was the data breached discovered?

PhilHealth's IT personnel detected anomalous network activity and discovered that servers had been encrypted. The Medusa gang itself also publicly announced the attack and posted the stolen data after the ransom deadline passed.

8. What actions were done by the company during and after the breach?

- IT personnel immediately disconnected network connections to contain the ransomware spread
- Promptly reported the incident to DICT, NPC, PNP Cybercrime Division, CICC, and NBI
- Initially and incorrectly claimed 'no personal information has been compromised' — later contradicted by investigations
- PhilHealth Board of Directors reassigned seven Executive Committee members in connection with the breach
- Issued a public urgent notice on October 2, 2023 advising protective measures
- Failed to notify approximately 42 million affected individuals within the 72-hour DPA requirement — drew severe criticism

9. What preventive actions were installed by the company?

PhilHealth committed to enhancing its security measures and procuring renewed antivirus software. Both the DICT and PhilHealth clarified that the main members' database, which contains sensitive information such as claims, contributions, and accreditation details, was not part of the affected servers. The NPC also set up the PhilHealthLeak search portal (philhealthleak.privacy.gov.ph) to allow members to verify if their data was compromised.

10. What actions were done by government authorities?

- NPC issued a Notice to Explain and Order to Appear to PhilHealth on September 25, 2023, followed by an Onsite Investigation on September 28, 2023
- NPC created the PhilHealthLeak Search Portal (philhealthleak.privacy.gov.ph) in April 2024



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- House of Representatives held hearings in July 2024 grilling PhilHealth and NPC officials about the breach
- DICT Undersecretary Jeffrey Dy led technical analysis and warned the public against accessing malware-laden files
- House Resolution 1392 directed the House ICT Committee to investigate the string of cyberattacks against government agencies

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BREACH NO. 3 — Philippine Statistics Authority (PSA)

CBMS Data Breach — 2023

1. What company was breached (provide brief background)?

The Philippine Statistics Authority (PSA) is the primary statistical arm of the Philippine government. It is responsible for national censuses, the civil registration system (birth, marriage, and death certificates), administering the Philippine Identification System (PhilSys), and managing the Community-Based Monitoring System (CBMS) — a data collection system used by local government units to gather socioeconomic data on households for poverty alleviation programs such as the 4Ps.

2. When the data breach happened?

On October 7, 2023, information about an alleged data leak involving a system managed by the PSA was posted by a certain actor on social media. This occurred just days after the PhilHealth ransomware attack, amid what authorities described as a surge in cyberattacks on Philippine government agencies.

3. How the data breach was done?

Unlike the concurrent PhilHealth attack, the PSA CBMS breach did not involve ransomware. The CBMS system was not publicly accessible and could only be reached from within PSA regional offices, which led authorities to consider an insider threat as the leading theory. An unknown actor posted alleged sample data including blurred photos of IDs on social media on October 7, 2023. The exact technical attack vector was not fully disclosed publicly to avoid compromising the ongoing investigation. DICT Undersecretary Jeffrey Dy confirmed the attack vector did not match the Medusa ransomware used in the PhilHealth attack. The motivation appeared to be notoriety rather than financial gain, as no ransom was demanded.

4. Who committed the data breach if identifiable?

Identity not confirmed. Suspected to be a possible insider or individual with internal knowledge of PSA regional office systems. PSA's Data Protection Officer stated authorities already had leads on the identity of the attacker.

5. When was the data breach reported to the public and to the authorities?

The NPC confirmed that the PSA submitted a breach notification on October 10, 2023. On Wednesday, October 11, the PSA admitted that it may have had a breach and



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alerted the National Privacy Commission after various posts appeared online showing blurred photos of IDs and personal information.

6. What data was stolen?

- Demographic data from CBMS household socioeconomic surveys
- Health, nutrition, water, and sanitation data of low-income households
- Shelter, education, income, and employment data
- Security-related data of households enrolled in poverty alleviation programs
- Volume of records not officially disclosed; CBMS covers multiple municipalities

7. How the data breach was discovered?

An unknown actor posted alleged sample data on social media on October 7, 2023, including blurred photos of IDs and personal information from CBMS records. The posts also contained malware-laden links consistent with the tactics seen in the PhilHealth leak.

8. What actions were done by the company during and after the breach?

- PSA immediately activated its Data Breach Response Team (DBRT) on October 7, 2023
- Shut down and isolated the affected CBMS system to prevent further unauthorized access
- Filed a formal breach notification with the NPC on October 10, 2023
- Publicly assured that the PhilSys (national ID) and Civil Registration System were NOT affected
- Warned the public against clicking on malware-containing social media links
- Coordinated closely with NPC, DICT's NCERT-PH, and PNP Anti-Cybercrime Group

9. What preventive actions were installed by the company?

- Implemented additional access controls and monitoring on CBMS-related systems
- Shut down and isolated the CBMS system pending a full security audit
- Committed to strengthening technical, organizational, and physical security measures
- The incident highlighted the need for insider threat programs and stricter access control policies

10. What actions were done by government authorities, if any?

The PSA coordinated with the Compliance and Monitoring Division of the NPC, the National Computer Emergency Response Team-Philippines (NCERT-PH) of the DICT, and the Anti-Cybercrime Group of the Philippine National Police (PNP) in relation to the matter. DICT Undersecretary Jeffrey Dy warned the public that malware was found in



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files related to the PSA breach, used by hackers as a means to attack more individuals
— especially curious people looking at the stolen files.

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BREACH NO. 4 — GCash (G-Xchange, Inc.)

Unauthorized Transactions & Alleged Data Breach — 2022–2025

1. What company was breached (provide brief background)?

GCash is the Philippines' largest mobile wallet and digital payments platform, operated by G-Xchange, Inc. (GXI), a subsidiary of Globe Telecom. As of 2023, GCash reported over 76 million registered users, making it the dominant fintech platform in the country. GCash is regulated by the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas (BSP) and supervised by the National Privacy Commission.

2. When the data breach happened?

Multiple incidents: May 9, 2022 (major unauthorized transaction incident); November 9, 2024 (second unauthorized fund transfer incident); October 25–26, 2025 (alleged dark web data sale).

3. How the data breach was done?

The primary 2022 incident involved a phishing scheme. Unknown cybercriminals created fraudulent online gambling websites ('Philwin' and 'tapwin1.com') designed to harvest GCash user credentials. Unsuspecting users entered their GCash MPINs on these fake sites; attackers then accessed victim accounts and transferred funds to East West Bank and Asia United Bank. GCash maintained no breach of its internal systems occurred, a position validated by the NPC's May 2023 findings. In November 2024, a second incident involved users reporting unauthorized fund transfers which GCash attributed to 'errors in an ongoing system reconciliation process.' In October 2025, a threat actor ('Oversleep8351') claimed to sell GCash user KYC data on the dark web; GCash denied any breach and said the alleged dataset did not originate from its infrastructure.

4. Who committed the data breach if identifiable?

The perpetrators were described as "unknown threat actors" who utilized online gambling platforms to carry out the phishing scheme. Additionally, a separate dark web post surfaced on October 25 of the same year by a threat actor using the alias "Oversleep8351," allegedly offering GCash merchant and basic user data, GCash account numbers, linked bank and virtual card accounts, and KYC (Know Your Customer) records for sale.



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5. When was the data breach reported to the public and to the authorities?

On May 10, 2023, the NPC issued a Notice to Explain and an order addressed to GXI, requiring it to appear before the Commission for a clarificatory meeting. The clarificatory meeting was held on May 12, 2023. The NPC ordered an in-depth investigation on Saturday (after May 9), amid reports on social media citing suspicious transactions piling up.

6. What data was stolen?

- GCash account credentials (MPINs) — obtained via phishing by attackers
- Linked bank account details accessed by fraudsters
- In the 2025 alleged breach: KYC records, account numbers, Philippine IDs, employment details (alleged by threat actor, unconfirmed)
- Number of affected users not publicly disclosed for the 2022 incident

7. How the data breach was discovered?

Days before the NPC released its statement, users of the platform took to social media to air their frustration, as some allegedly reported unauthorized transactions that funneled their money from the digital wallet to certain bank accounts affiliated with East West Bank and Asia United Bank. The surge in complaints and GCash's unusual maintenance downtime brought the issue to public and regulatory attention.

8. What actions were done by the company during and after the breach?

- Activated emergency maintenance mode on May 9, 2022 upon detecting unauthorized transactions
- Deployed security protocols and froze suspicious transactions
- Launched the DoubleSafe biometric (facial recognition) feature in March 2023 for new device logins
- Coordinated with NPC and BSP, providing all requested documents and data for investigation
- Intensified user education and awareness campaigns on phishing per NPC orders
- Committed to continued investment in cybersecurity technologies

9. What preventive actions were installed by the company?

GCash requires multiple levels of authentication before a user can access an account, through a one-time PIN and a mobile PIN. GCash also rolled out in March 2023 its DoubleSafe feature, which requires clients to confirm their identity via facial recognition before accessing their GCash accounts on a new device. The NPC additionally ordered



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GXI to intensify its education and awareness campaigns for its clients to prevent similar incidents.

10. What actions were done by government authorities, if any?

The NPC's Complaints and Investigation Division conducted an independent investigation to ascertain the extent of the alleged unauthorized transactions and determine if there was a possible compromise of personal data. The Cybercrime Investigation and Coordinating Center (CICC) announced it was investigating the possibility of an "organized breach of certain GCash accounts," and the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas (BSP) ordered GXI to fix the issues immediately and required regular update submissions. The NPC ordered GXI to intensify its education and awareness campaign to its clients to prevent similar incidents in the future.

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BREACH NO. 5 — Philippine Airlines (PAL)

Mabuhay Miles / Accelya Supply-Chain Breach — 2022

1. What company was breached (provide brief background)?

Philippine Airlines (PAL) is the national flag carrier of the Philippines and the oldest commercial airline in Asia still operating under its original name. Founded in 1941 and headquartered in Pasay City, Metro Manila, PAL operates international and domestic flights serving millions of passengers annually. PAL runs the Mabuhay Miles frequent flyer program, one of the largest airline loyalty programs in the Philippines, managed by third-party IT provider Accelya Group.

2. When the data breach happened?

August–September 2022 — the cyberattack targeted Accelya Group's global systems. PAL was notified by Accelya on or before September 8, 2022.

3. How the data breach was done?

The breach was a supply-chain attack — PAL's own internal IT systems were not directly compromised. Attackers targeted Accelya Group, a global technology firm providing IT services to over 250 airlines worldwide. When Accelya's systems were compromised via malware/ransomware, data belonging to multiple airline clients — including PAL — was simultaneously put at risk. PAL was one of several airlines globally affected. The breach specifically impacted only Mabuhay Miles members who enrolled between 2015 and 2017. PAL's own internal IT infrastructure, flight operations, and booking systems remained completely unaffected.

4. Who committed the data breach if identifiable?

Unknown threat actors who targeted Accelya Group's global infrastructure. The attack reportedly used ransomware or malware similar to attacks that simultaneously hit other Accelya airline clients worldwide.

5. When was the data breach reported to the public and to the authorities?

PAL was notified by Accelya on or before September 8, 2022. PAL publicly confirmed the breach and notified affected Mabuhay Miles members on September 10–12, 2022, and reported to the NPC at the same time.



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6. What data was stolen?

- Full names and dates of birth
- Nationality and gender
- Join date and membership tier level
- Mabuhay Miles points balance
- Notably NOT compromised: contact details, credit card information, passport numbers, account passwords, or flight ticketing information
- Affected subset: Mabuhay Miles members who joined from 2015 to 2017 ('at most 12% of the membership roster')

7. How the data breach was discovered?

Accelya Group, PAL's third-party IT service provider for the Mabuhay Miles program, detected and reported the cybersecurity incident affecting its own systems and notified PAL.

8. What actions were done by the company during and after the breach?

- Upon notification from Accelya, PAL immediately alerted affected Mabuhay Miles members via email, advising password changes as a precaution
- Publicly confirmed on September 10–12, 2022 that only limited information was affected and PAL's own systems were fully secure
- Reported the breach to the NPC in compliance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012
- Coordinated closely with Accelya and urged the provider to fortify its security measures
- PAL SVP and Data Protection Officer Alvin Limqueco publicly assured members of data protection priority

9. What preventive actions were installed by the company?

- PAL urged and coordinated with Accelya to implement additional security hardening on its global infrastructure
- Accelya confirmed to PAL it stopped malware spread and implemented further security measures
- The incident underscored the importance of robust third-party vendor risk management
- PAL reviewed its data-sharing agreements and contractual security obligations with all third-party IT service providers

10. What actions were done by government authorities, if any?

- The NPC received PAL's breach notification and monitored compliance with required notification procedures



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- The NPC assessed whether PAL's third-party data processing arrangements with Accelya complied with the Data Privacy Act's requirements for personal information processors
- No further regulatory action was publicly disclosed, as the breach was limited in scope and PAL acted promptly

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